

Around the body

To work efficiently, your body's trillions of cells need nonstop supplies of oxygen and food. This delivery service is provided by your blood, which flows continuously through an incredible branching network of tubes called blood vessels. The driving force behind this delivery service is your heart. Together the heart, blood, and blood vessels make up the circulatory system.

SUPER-FAST

Weaving through every part of your body are arteries and veins. These blood vessels are linked by capillaries, which are too small to be seen here. The shortest return journey that blood makes is from the heart to its own muscles, which takes a matter of seconds. The longest journey—to the toes and back—takes no more than a minute. Arteries carry blood away from the heart, while veins carry blood toward it.

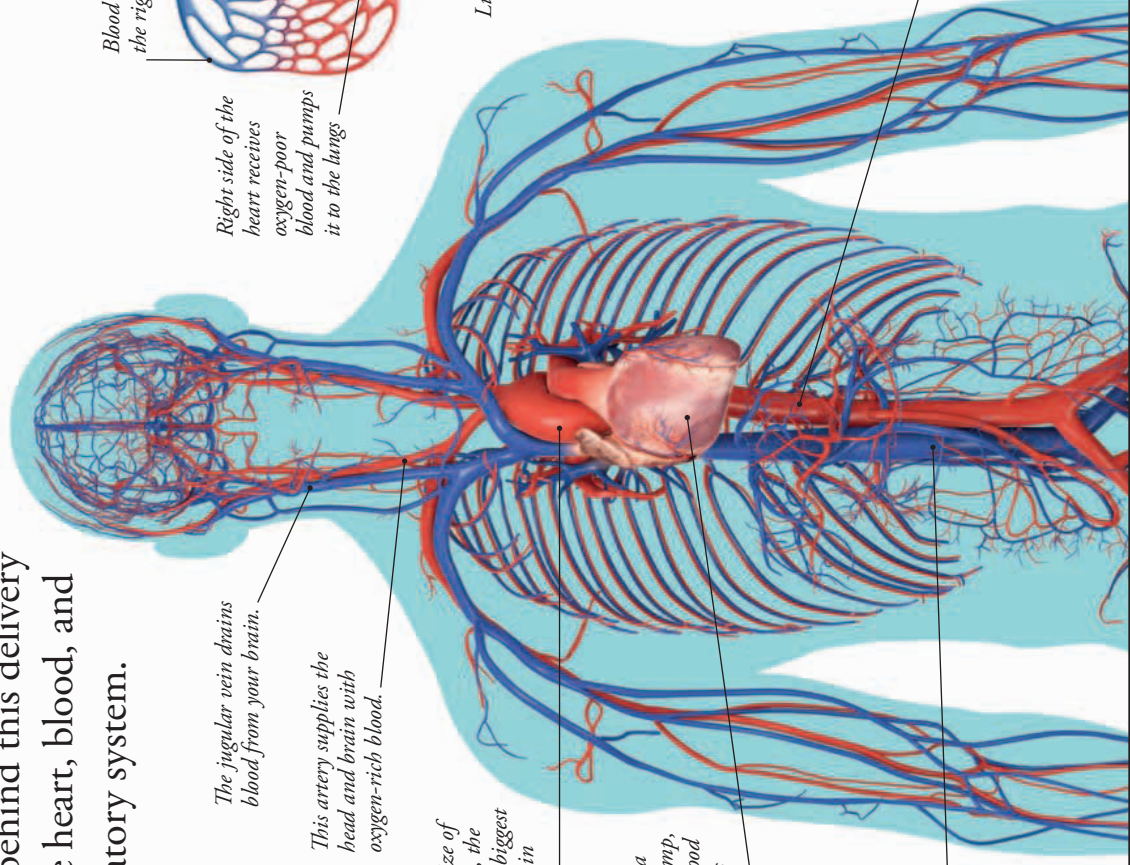
The biggest vein in your body, the inferior vena cava, returns used blood from the lower part of your body.

About the size of your thumb, the aorta is the biggest blood vessel in your body.

The heart is a muscular pump, supplying blood to your lungs and body.

The jugular vein drains blood from your brain.

This artery supplies the head and brain with oxygen-rich blood.



NEVER-ENDING JOURNEY

Blood travels around your body in one direction through two loops. Linked by the heart, the shorter loop (blue arrows) carries blood to the lungs, where it picks up fresh oxygen. It then returns to the heart, taking oxygen-rich blood to the rest of your body along the longer loop (yellow arrows).

